THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Level 0

Ten rooms: sitting and hands, the keyboard, fingering, the staff, the beat, notes and rests one at a time, loud and soft. Read each room, listen to it in the app, then practise.

THE ROOMS

1 · Posture and hand shape
2 · The keyboard
3 · Fingering
4 · The staff and the clefs
5 · Pulse, tempo and the bar
6 · Notes: the crotchet
7 · Notes: the minim
8 · Notes: three beats
9 · Notes: the semibreve
10 · Loud and soft

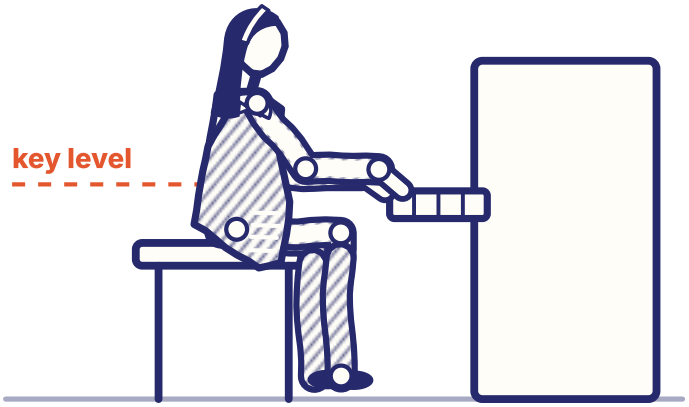
LEVEL 0 · ROOM 1

Posture and hand shape

Handbook pp. 18–20 · listen in the app: Room 1

THE SECRET

Sit tall, forearms level with the keys, a round hand on the fingertips: then let the arm's weight do the work.

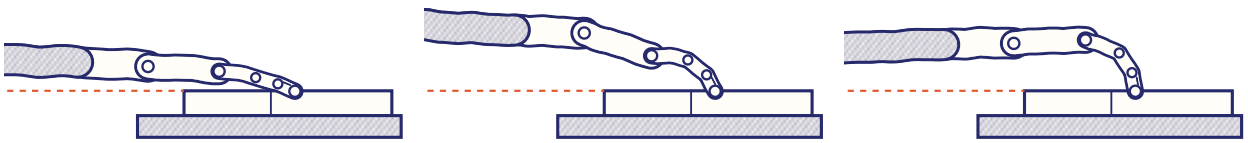


1. **forearms level with the keys**
   wrist neither dropped nor lifted
2. **elbows a little in front of you**
   not pinned to your sides
3. **sit on the front half of the stool**
   opposite Middle C
4. **feet flat on the floor**
   the right foot near the pedal
5. **back tall, shoulders loose**
   lean a little towards the keys

Tall back, level arms, flat feet

EXAMPLE 1

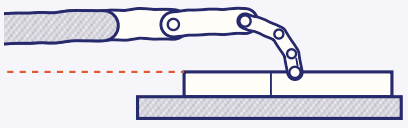
Which hand is round?



1. **Look at the knuckles:** up, or sunk in?
2. **Look at the tips:** does the finger stand on its tip?
3. **Which hand** could play all day?

C: knuckles up, curved fingers, standing on the tips. A is flat; B's knuckle has caved in.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



The ball test.

Hold a small ball or an orange, then put the hand on the keys without changing its shape. That is your playing hand.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 1 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Finger numbers

★☆☆

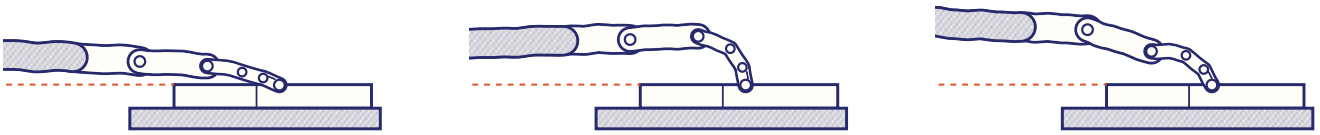
Write the number of each finger. They are the same in both hands. The first is done.

FINGER	NUMBER	FINGER	NUMBER
thumb	1	ring finger	
index finger		little finger	
middle finger			

2 Which hand is round?

★☆☆

Circle the round hand.



A B C

3 Too low, too high, or right?

★★☆

Write too low, too high or right.

WHAT YOU SEE	THE STOOL IS
The elbows are well below the keys; the forearms go uphill.	too low
The forearms are level with the keys.	
The elbows are above the keys; the wrists drop down to them.	

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 2

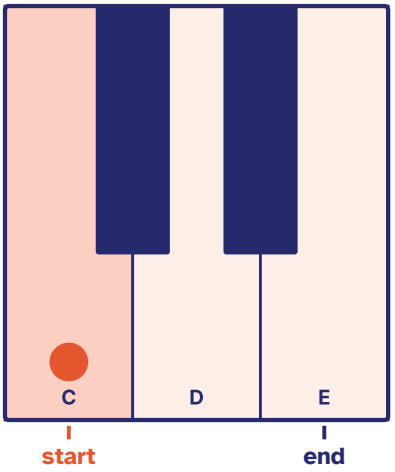
The keyboard

Handbook pp. 22–26 · listen in the app: Room 2

THE SECRET

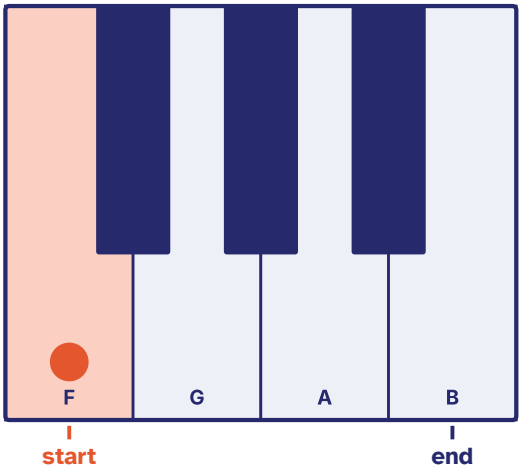
Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.

2 black keys: C D E



on the piano E and F touch

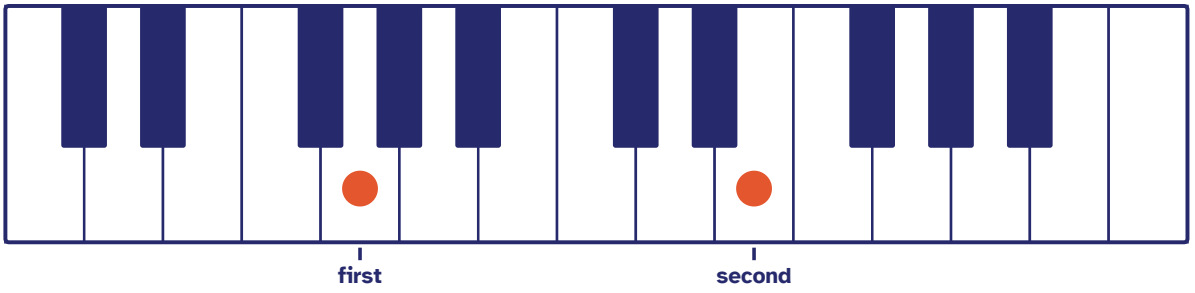
3 black keys: F G A B



Pulled apart: each family has a first key (start) and a last key (end)

EXAMPLE 1

Higher or lower?



1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 2 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Twos and threes

★☆☆

Circle every group of two black keys and every group of three. How many of each?

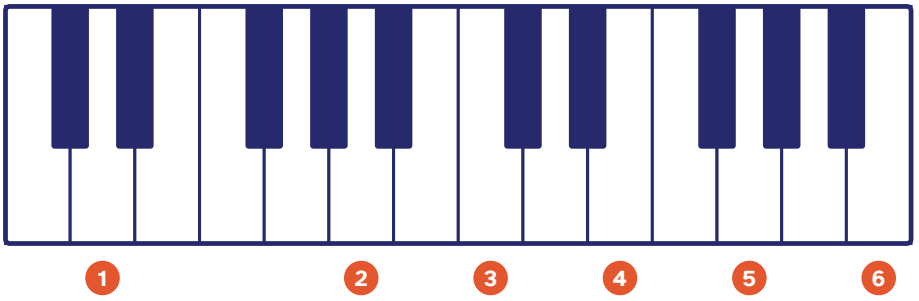


groups of two ☐ groups of three ☐

2 Name the keys

★☆☆

Find the group, then its first key, then walk on. Write the letter name of each numbered key. The first is done.



1 D 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐

3 Round and round

★☆☆

Seven letters, A to G, then A again. Write the next three letters: going up on the left, going down on the right. The first is done.

GOING UP	GOING DOWN
E F G **A B C**	C B A **G F E**
F G A	B A G
A B C	D C B

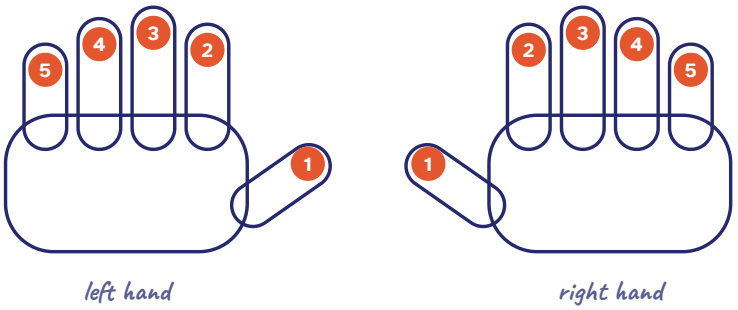
LEVEL 0 · ROOM 3

Fingering

Handbook pp. 163–164 · listen in the app: Room 3

THE SECRET

Thumbs are 1 in both hands. Choose a fingering once, write it in, keep it.
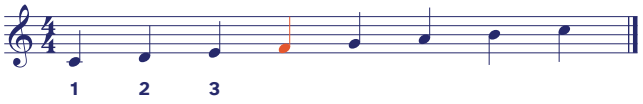


left hand *right hand*

Thumbs are 1 in both hands

EXAMPLE 1

Which finger plays the F?



?

1. **C D E** are 1 2 3.
2. **The F:** finger 4, or the thumb tucked under?
3. **Then** how do you reach the top C?

The **thumb** passes under to F; then 2 3 4 5 reach the top C.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 3 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Five-finger position ★☆☆

Right-hand thumb on C, left-hand little finger on C: write the finger for each note. The first is done.

	C	D	E	F	G
right hand	1				
left hand					

2 C major, right hand ★★☆

Write the fingering going up. The first three are done.

	C	D	E	F	G	A	B	C
finger	1	2	3					

3 Play it ★☆☆

Play C D E F G up and down with each hand, saying the finger numbers. Tick a circle each day.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

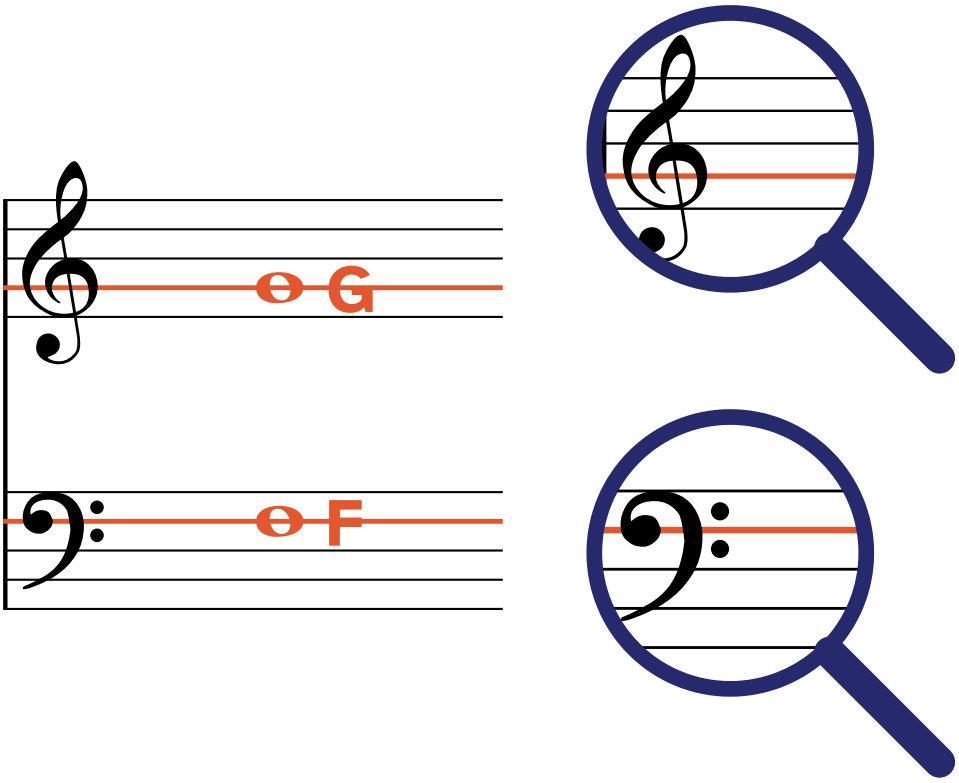
LEVEL 0 · ROOM 4

The staff and the clefs

Handbook pp. 27–28 · listen in the app: Room 4

THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.



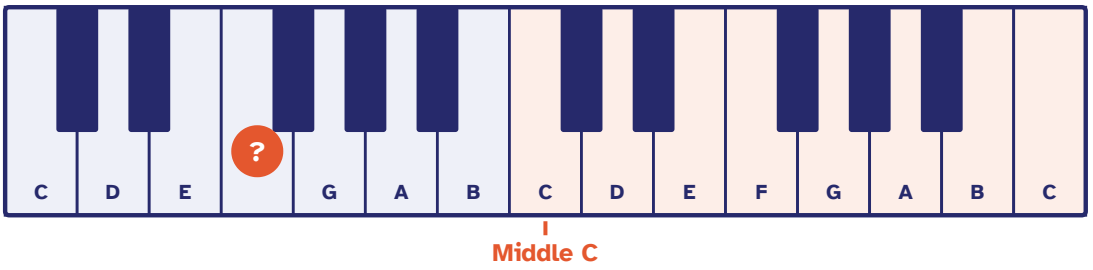
Treble clef = G clef
curls round line 2: G

Bass clef = F clef
its dots hug line 4: F

The treble clef is the G clef: it curls round G · the bass clef is the F clef: its dots hug F

EXAMPLE

Which staff is this key written on?



1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 4 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 The clefs ★☆☆

Write the name of each clef and the note it marks.

CLEF	NAME	IT MARKS THE LINE FOR
		
		

2 Line or space? ★☆☆

Circle line or space, then write its number (counted from the bottom). The first is done.

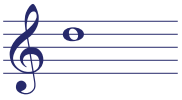


line · space
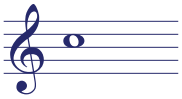
1



line · space



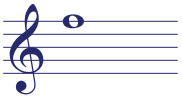
line · space



line · space



line · space



line · space

3 Treble or bass? ★☆☆

Which staff would each note usually be written on? The first is done.

the E above Middle C	treble · bass
Bass C	treble · bass
High C	treble · bass
the lowest key on the piano	treble · bass
Treble C	treble · bass

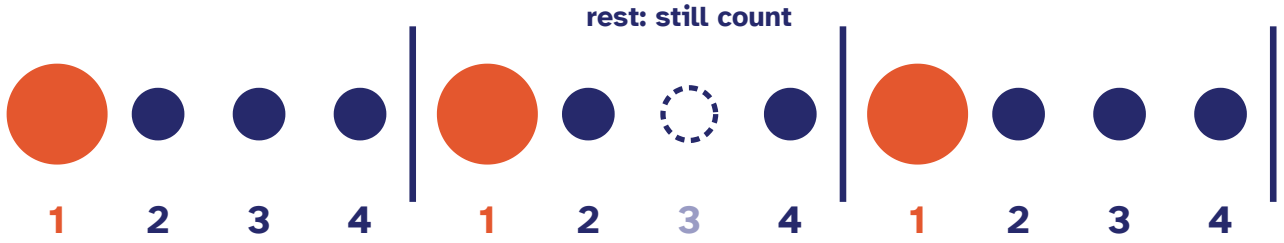
LEVEL 0 · ROOM 5

Pulse, tempo and the bar

Handbook pp. 50–52 · listen in the app: Room 5

THE SECRET

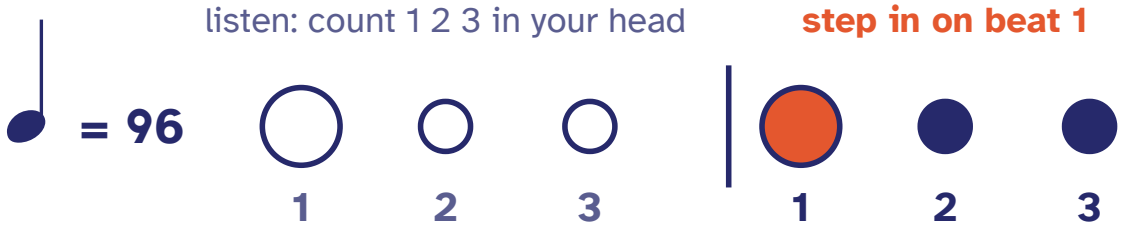
The beat never stops, not even in a rest. Feel it before you play.



Beat 1 of every bar is the strongest

EXAMPLE 1

Feel the beat before you play



1. **Read the mark:** ♩ **= 96**, 96 crotchet beats a minute.
2. **Listen first:** set the metronome and let one full bar go by, counting “1 2 3” in your head.
3. **Step in** on the next beat 1, the way you step onto a moving escalator.

The first note lands **on the beat**, not a guess.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hand on your heart. Tap the beat.

Say “1 2 3 4” with your taps, 1 a little louder. Keep going for ten seconds without slowing down.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 5 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Count it ★★☆

Write a count in every box: the beat you play, then the beats you hold. The first bar is done.



2 Add the bar lines ★★☆

Draw a bar line after every full bar and a final bar line at the end.





3 Clap and count ★☆☆

Set a metronome to ♩ = **60**. Clap on the notes, open your hands on the rests, count aloud. Tick a circle each time it is steady.



○ ○ ○ ○ ○

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 6

Notes: the crotchet

Handbook pp. 53–55 · listen in the app: Room 6

4 crotchets



LEVEL 0 · ROOM 6 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 How many beats?

★☆☆

Write the number of beats under each one. The first is done.



2 Play and count

★★☆

Say the counts out loud and play: a crotchet is play, a rest is shh. Write 1 2 3 4 under the bar.



3 Draw it

★★☆

Draw four crotchets, then two crotchet rests (a little lightning bolt).

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 7

Notes: the minim

Handbook pp. 53–55 · listen in the app: Room 7

2 minims



4 crotchets



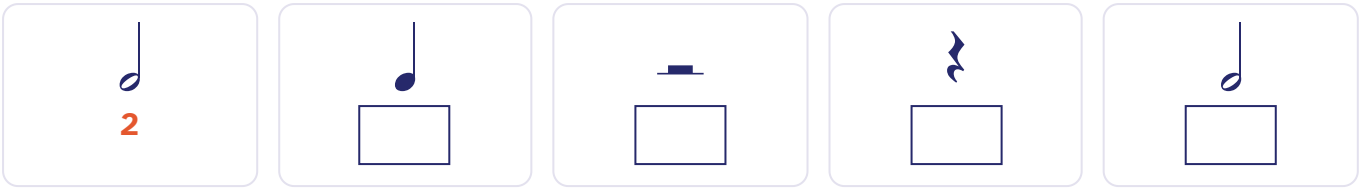
LEVEL 0 · ROOM 7 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 One beat or two?

★☆☆

Write 1 or 2 under each. The first is done.



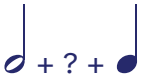
2 Fill the bar

★★☆

Four beats in each bar. Write the missing note: crotchet or minim. The first is done.



minim





3 The hat

★★☆

Draw a minim rest: a block sitting on the middle line, like a hat. Then draw two minims.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 8

Notes: three beats

Handbook pp. 53–55 · listen in the app: Room 8



2 beats

2 + 1 = 3 beats

The dot adds half

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 8 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 How many beats?

★☆☆

Write the number of beats. The first is done.



2 Waltz time

★★☆

Each bar has three beats. Count 1 2 3 and play. Which note fills the whole bar?



3 Add the dot

★★☆

Make each minim last three beats: draw the dot after it.



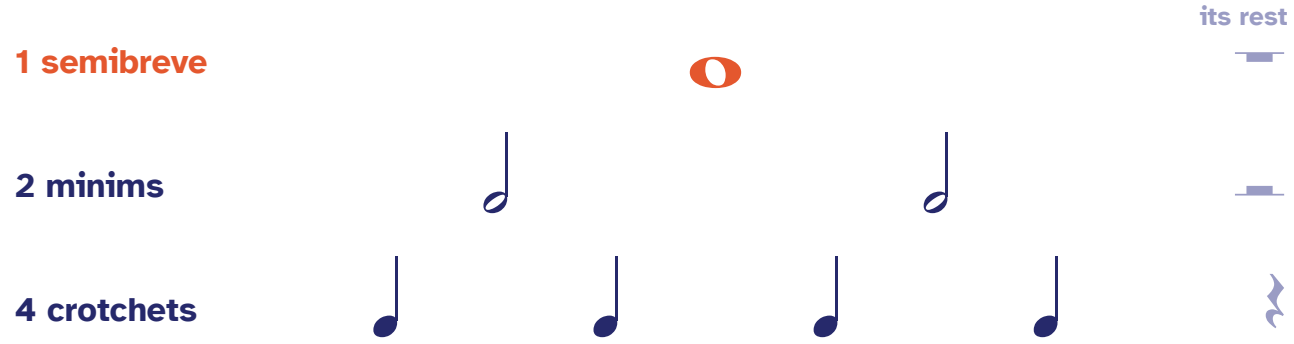
LEVEL 0 · ROOM 9

Notes: the semibreve

Handbook pp. 53–55 · listen in the app: Room 9

THE SECRET

Each note is half the one above it, and every note has a rest twin.



Each note splits into two of the next

EXAMPLE 1

How long is each sound, and each silence?



1. **Name each shape** in the bar.
2. **How many beats** does each one last?
3. **Add them up,** rests included. What is the total?

Minim 2, crotchet 1, crotchet rest 1: every bar adds up to **4 beats**, silences included.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 9 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Name, beats and rest

★☆☆

Fill in the table. The first row is done.

NOTE	NAME	BEATS	ITS REST
	semibreve	4	
			
			
			–

2 Coat or hat?

★☆☆

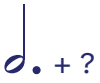
The semibreve rest hangs like a coat; the minim rest sits like a hat. Write coat or hat.

coat			

3 Four beats

★★☆

Each bar must add up to four beats. Write the missing note.

 + ?	crotchet
 + ?	
? (one note)	

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 10

Loud and soft

Handbook pp. 76–78 · listen in the app: Room 10



pp	*p*	*mp*	*mf*	*f*	*ff*
very soft	soft	half soft	half loud	loud	very loud
pianissimo	***piano***	***mezzo-piano***	***mezzo-forte***	***forte***	***fortissimo***

Six steps from a whisper to a shout

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

pp* → *ff

One note, six ways.

Play Middle C *pp*, then *p*, *mp*, *mf*, *f*, *ff*: six different steps, using the weight of your arm. Then come back down.

LEVEL 0 · ROOM 10 · PRACTISE

Practise

1 Say it

★☆☆

Write the Italian name and what it means. The first row is done.

SIGN	NAME	MEANS
p	piano	soft
mf		
ff		
mp		
pp		
f		

2 Play it

★☆☆

Play Middle C six times: pp, p, mp, mf, f, ff. Six different steps? Tick a circle each day.